

Addressing Urbanization and Urban Challenges in Lagos

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The state of a city is the most reliable audit of its government. It reflects, without embellishment, the quality of its planning, the strength of its institutions, and the discipline with which policy is executed.

Lagos offers a clear case in point. It is a city of scale, ambition, and undeniable economic significance. But it is also a city under strain. Rapid urbanisation has continued without a commensurate expansion of the systems required to sustain it. What this has produced is not simply growth, but pressure on infrastructure, on the environment, and increasingly, on social cohesion.

When I assumed office in 2007, Lagos was a city of over fifteen million people already grappling with many of these realities of rapid urbanisation with existing plans for cushioning the infrastructure needing either revamping or disciplined implementation. The challenge at the time was not merely to expand the city, but to begin the process of structuring it, to move from a pattern of reactive interventions to one guided by a deliberate plan. That task has proven to be an infinite challenge, not for lack of effort, but because urbanisation has continued at a pace that consistently tests the limits of existing systems.

This is the central issue. Urbanisation, in itself, is not the problem. Cities are meant to grow. The question is whether that growth is organised or incidental.

The functionality of a city is determined not by its scale, but by the degree of coherence across its governing systems. Transport, water, energy, and land use constitute an interdependent architecture that must be designed and managed as a unified whole. Where such integration is incomplete, inefficiency becomes institutionalised, and when sustained over time, such inefficiencies give rise to disorder as a structural condition rather than a temporary disruption. From this perspective, the urban challenges confronting Lagos are neither incidental nor unexpected; they are the inevitable manifestations of systemic misalignment between rapid urban growth and the capacity of underlying infrastructure and governance frameworks.

Experience across the continent suggests that this trajectory is neither inevitable nor irreversible.

Comparative urban experience suggests that similar challenges, when approached through coherent systems and institutional discipline, can yield markedly different outcomes. Dar es Salaam's Bus Rapid Transit introduced order into informal mobility systems; Cape Town

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embedded demand regulation in response to water scarcity; and Addis Ababa's light rail demonstrates the results of long-term planning anchored in institutional continuity.

Taken together, these examples point to a clear pattern. Urban challenges are not defined by scarcity of ideas or resources, but by the absence of structured planning and sustained execution. Cities do not fail because they lack capacity; they falter because that capacity is not organised into functioning systems. For Lagos, addressing urbanisation requires a similar clarity of approach.

As Governor, I advanced the Blue Line rail project in Lagos and expanded the BRT corridors, alongside investments in drainage and institutional reform. Those experiences made one point clear: what distinguishes transformative outcomes from incremental progress is not political will, but the quality of the plan, and the discipline to execute it.

Development, therefore, cannot be driven by projects alone. Roads will be built, and drainage will be expanded, but without a framework that integrates these investments into a coherent system, their impact remains limited. The task is to move from projects to systems, and from short-term responses to sustained planning.

Nigeria's urban management has too often been driven by political will in search of a plan, rather than political will in the service of one.

Such a shift has practical implications. Systems do not sustain themselves; they are underpinned by the mechanisms through which they are financed, managed, and measured. At the scale of Lagos, infrastructure development must be supported by financing models that align long-term investment with long-term returns; strengthening internally generated revenue, leveraging public-private partnerships where appropriate, and exploring instruments capable of funding large-scale urban systems.

Equally, the effectiveness of urban systems depends on the quality of information that supports them. London demonstrates this through congestion charging and the use of transport data to manage demand. Without reliable data, systems cannot be calibrated, and policy remains reactive rather than anticipatory.

There is also the question of informality, which remains central to how Lagos functions. Transport networks, housing patterns, and economic activity often operate outside formal structures, yet they are deeply embedded in the life of the city. Addressing urban challenges, therefore, requires not simply replacing informal systems, but understanding and integrating them in ways that improve efficiency while preserving livelihoods.

This speaks to a broader principle. Urban systems must not only be efficient; they must be inclusive. Lagos is not only a megacity; it is also a homeland. As it expands, it must ensure that growth does not create a disconnect between opportunity and belonging. A city that becomes economically vibrant but socially exclusive is not sustainable. Inclusion is not a matter of sentiment; it is a condition for stability.

At the same time, these systems must be resilient. As a coastal city, Lagos faces environmental pressures that extend beyond immediate concerns such as drainage and flooding. Long-term planning must incorporate climate considerations; coastal protection, sustainable land use, and energy systems that reduce vulnerability over time.

In my experience, meeting these conditions requires a set of priorities working in concert. Mass transit must operate at a scale that reflects the size of the city. Water and drainage must be treated as essential infrastructure, not secondary concerns. Energy systems must be strengthened to support productivity and quality of life. Above all, institutions must be built and sustained in a way that allows policy to outlive political cycles.

One area where greater discipline is required is maintenance. There is a tendency in public administration to emphasise new projects, often at the expense of existing assets. This approach is unsustainable. No city becomes functional by what it builds alone, but by what it maintains consistently. Infrastructure that is neglected does not simply deteriorate; it erodes the gains that have already been made.

Addressing urbanisation in Lagos is, ultimately, a question of governance.

The issues are well understood. The solutions are not unfamiliar. What remains is the application of discipline—discipline in planning, in execution, and in maintenance.

The future of Lagos will not be determined by the pace of its growth, but by the quality of the systems that support it. That is the standard by which progress should be measured, and the responsibility that must be met.